ABOUT THIS PIECE

Lesson plan: resilience in The Outsiders

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WHAT IT IS

A 40 to 45 minute interdisciplinary 5th-grade lesson (ELA 5.8 and SS 5.5) on resilience in The Outsiders, connected to real historical figures.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

How an English lesson and a social studies standard work together.

5TH GRADE · STUDENT TEACHING · ELA 5.8 + SS 5.5

Resilience in The Outsiders

An Interdisciplinary Character Analysis Lesson

STANDARDS
ELA 5.8 — character development · SS 5.5 — societal challenges & response

TIME
40–45 minutes

TEXT
The Outsiders, Ch. 4 — the church fire rescue scene

Objective

Students will analyze how Ponyboy Curtis demonstrates resilience through his relationships and challenges in *The Outsiders*, connecting the theme to real historical figures.

Materials

- Excerpt from The Outsiders, Chapter 4 (the church fire rescue scene)
- Character map graphic organizer
- Discussion prompts
- Whiteboard and markers
- Optional: film clip of the church fire rescue scene

Lesson Procedure

Pre-Reading (5 min)
Show an image or short video about resilience (e.g. a historical figure or athlete overcoming a challenge). Ask: “What does resilience mean to you? Can you think of a time you had to stay calm under pressure?”

During Reading (20 min)
Read the excerpt aloud as a class or in small groups, pausing for guided questions: “What challenge does Ponyboy face in this scene? How does he react to the fire? What does this say about his character?” Students complete a character map — challenge, traits demonstrated, and outcome.

Post-Reading (15 min)
Group discussion comparing Ponyboy's resilience to real-life examples: “How is Ponyboy similar to a historical figure like Rosa Parks or Jackie Robinson?” Students then write a short reflection (5–7 sentences) on how they can apply resilience in their own lives.

Character Map — Example

Challenge	Traits Demonstrated	Outcome
The church fire rescue	Bravery, selflessness	Ponyboy grows through the experience, deepening his sense of purpose

Assessment

Review completed character maps for understanding, and evaluate written reflections for a genuine connection to the theme of resilience.

Differentiation

Provide sentence starters for struggling writers (e.g. “One way Ponyboy shows resilience is…”) and offer simplified discussion prompts for students needing extra support.

Reflection

The guided reading and character map worked well and kept students engaged with the text. Some students needed more scaffolding for the reflective writing portion — next time, adding sentence starters and a modeled example response would help bridge that gap.